

Case Study 2: Ethics in an Unethical World

by Sophia



WHAT'S COVERED

In this case study, you will practice applying ethics in situations where there is pressure to bend the rules. Specifically, this scenario will include decisions about:

1. An Uneasy Interview

You sit nervously in the dimly lit conference room, waiting for the interviewer from Malum Corp. to arrive. You are desperate for a job and have applied to countless positions, but this was the first time you've made it to the interview stage. The job is described as Performance Improvement Specialist. You try to push away the unease you feel about the company's reputation as a ruthless employer and remind yourself a job is a job.

The interviewer arrives and after some perfunctory small talk, they get down to business. They explain that the position is for a supervisor who would monitor workers in the company's factory. You were intrigued, but as they continue to describe the job's duties, your unease returns.

The interviewer explains that Malum Corp. has a strict policy of monitoring their workers' every move to ensure maximum productivity. You feel a pang of discomfort at the thought of constantly watching over people, but you desperately need the job. It sounds like a rigid hierarchical culture, which is not your preference. The internal conflict is intense. On one hand, you need the job to support yourself, but on the other hand, you aren't sure you could live with yourself if you became the kind of person who watched over others constantly.

You are asked several questions about your ethics regarding monitoring others without their knowledge. You begin to suspect that they want you to be ethically flexible. If they offer you the job, you have a difficult decision to make. You can't help but wonder if taking this job would ultimately cost you your soul.



TRY IT

You have always believed in treating people with respect and trust, and the idea of spying on your colleagues makes you uneasy. You weigh your options as the interviewer continues talking, but your inner conflict remains. Do you compromise your values and accept the job, or do you reject it and risk financial instability?

You decide to listen to your conscience and decline the job offer. You walk out of the interview

feeling proud of yourself, knowing that you stayed true to your beliefs.

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You remember that your choices do change who you are, at least if we believe Aristotle. You cannot in good conscience accept a job with a company that violates the privacy and dignity of its employees through intrusive surveillance. Such actions are not only unethical but also illegal in many jurisdictions. As a responsible member of society, you cannot contribute to a culture of fear and mistrust in the workplace. Workers deserve respect and autonomy, and their personal data should not be used against them. Therefore, you decline this job offer and seek opportunities with companies that uphold the principles of privacy and respect for their employees.

Accept the job based on financial need.

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Accepting the job even though you have concerns is understandable, especially if it is a temporary position. However, unethical acts like intrusive surveillance of workers can't be justified solely based on financial need. Such a decision could compromise the privacy and dignity of employees, and could have negative consequences for both the individuals and society as a whole. It is important to consider other options, such as seeking out alternative job opportunities or seeking assistance from social welfare programs. Ultimately, it is crucial to prioritize ethical principles and values when making decisions that affect both oneself and others.

Ask for clarification.

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You ask the interviewer to clarify, and he confirms that intrusive worker surveillance is part of company policy and that the job you've applied for involves this practice. The interviewer insists that monitoring employees is necessary to ensure productivity and honesty. You still feel such surveillance intrudes on workers' privacy and autonomy. Employees may feel violated and distrusted when their every move is tracked, leading to a negative work environment and decreased morale. Additionally, the data collected by surveillance systems may be used in discriminatory ways, such as targeting workers based on their race or gender. Ethically, it is important for employers to balance their need for monitoring with respect for their employees' privacy and dignity. Workers have a right to know what is being monitored and why, and to have a say in the use of such technology.

Blow the whistle on Malum Corp. for intrusive surveillance.

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Whistleblowing about intrusive worker surveillance by Malum Corp. is an important act of ethical responsibility if you know the practices are illegal in your state. Such surveillance violates the basic human right to privacy and can have a chilling effect on employee productivity and job satisfaction. By exposing the wrongdoing of Malum Corp., whistleblowers can protect the rights of workers and prevent the company from engaging in unethical practices. However, whistleblowing can also have serious consequences for the whistleblower, including retaliation, harassment, and even loss of employment. It is important for whistleblowers to have proper legal protections and support to ensure their safety and well-being. Note that you would not be a whistleblower with legal protections until you accept the job, so there is additional ethical complication in accepting a job in bad faith.

2. Continuing Your Job Search

You did not choose to work for Malum Corp., but you still need a job. You observe a job announcement for a position at your local food bank. You arrive at the local food bank feeling nervous but hopeful. You've been looking for a job that will make a difference in your community, and you've always admired the work that the food bank does to help those in need. As you walk into the interview room, you notice the walls covered in posters and pictures of smiling volunteers and happy families receiving food. You feel a sense of warmth and purpose. The interviewer starts by explaining the importance of the food bank and how it provides a safety net for individuals and families who are struggling to make ends meet. They explain that the food bank relies on donations from the community and volunteers to distribute food to those in need. They also talk about the different programs and initiatives the food bank has implemented to address food insecurity, such as their mobile food pantry and community garden. Clearly, a clan culture has been created where everyone that works there—and utilizes the services—feels like family. You are much more comfortable with this than with the rigid hierarchical structure of the corporation where you applied for a job earlier.

As the interview goes on, you feel more and more inspired by the work that the food bank does. You realize that this job is not just about earning a paycheck, but it's about making a positive impact in people's lives—and this idea you like, because you've always wanted to focus on virtue ethics and development of your character. Although the salary is less than you hoped for, you feel this would start your career on the right note.

You go on a tour of the facility and observe a few things that give you pause, like a worker turning a person away who asks for support, or adding extra food to a box for a family they seem to know, but you really don't know enough about the situation to understand what is happening. You observe someone crying in the corner, ignored by staff, and it contradicts your mental image of what a food bank is all about. The manager tells you to pay them no mind. Still, it is enough to make you question if this is the job for you.

You leave the interview with mixed feelings. You know the local food bank plays an essential role in providing food assistance to individuals and families in need, and that working for the food bank can be an incredibly fulfilling experience. But you are concerned that the organization isn't as well regulated as it could be. You get a call the next day asking when you can start.



Do you accept the job with the food bank?

You accept the job.

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Congratulations! You've accepted a job at the local food bank! In spite of your reservations, your decision to work at the food bank is not only a wise career move but also a compassionate act of service to your community. By taking on this role, you'll have the opportunity to make a meaningful impact in the lives of those who rely on the food bank's services. You'll work alongside a dedicated team of individuals who share your passion for helping others, and you'll gain valuable experience in nonprofit work. You can deal with any concerns as you face them, changing the system from within after you have earned the trust and confidence of your colleagues. Get ready to roll up your sleeves, because you're about to embark on a fulfilling and rewarding journey!

You ask for clarification on what you observed.

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As you consider the job and ask for clarification, you can't help but feel concerned about the possibility of discrimination. You wonder if everyone will be treated equally, regardless of their background, race, or religion. Your heart aches as you think of the many people who may have faced discrimination before, and how much they may rely on the food bank to survive. Additionally, you worry about encountering emotionally vulnerable individuals who may be struggling with mental health issues or experiencing trauma, and being dismissed by staff. You hope that the staff and volunteers at the food bank are trained to handle these situations with empathy and kindness, creating a safe and supportive environment for all who seek assistance. Inquiring about your concerns is a wise move before you accept the job.

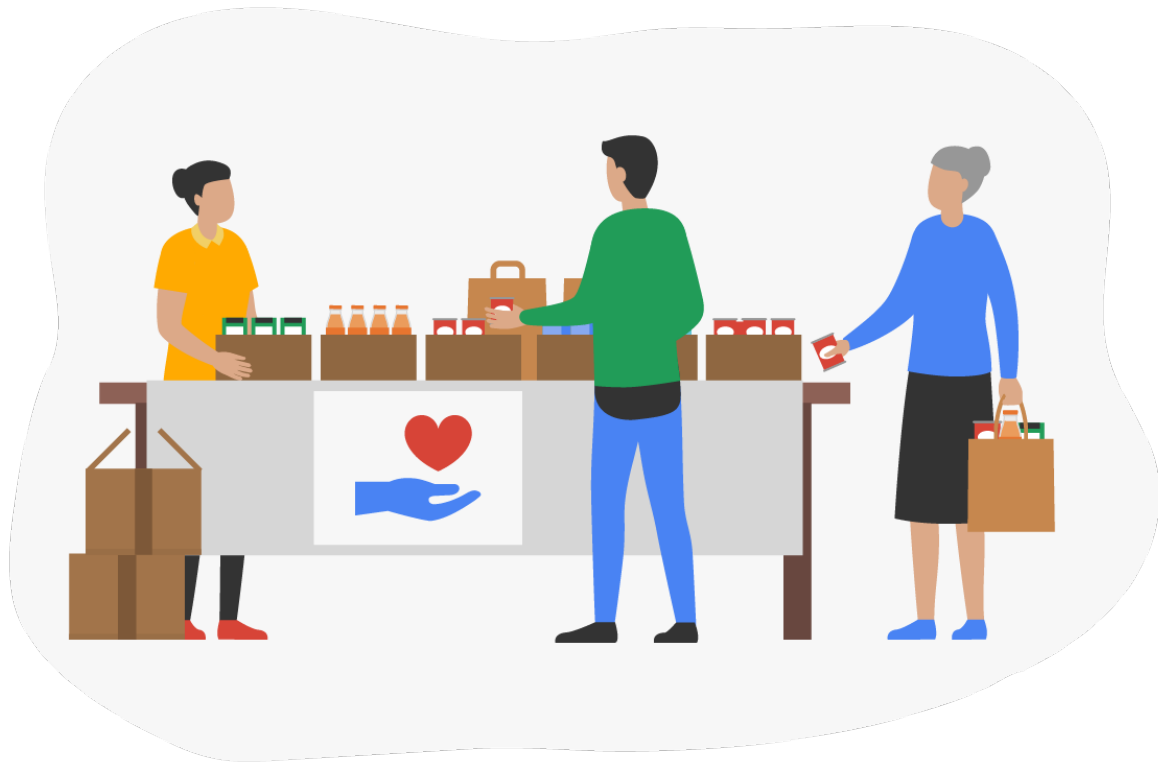
You tell the manager you appreciate the offer and will get back to them in a few days. You then research the organization more through informal networks and searching the news to find out if there have been complaints or legal troubles. +

This is an understandable step if you are concerned about the quality of the organization, and perhaps you will learn reassuring things that make accepting the job easier. However, it might be best to ask the questions directly of the people you met at the organization, to clear the air and start your working relationship with honesty and candor.

You decline the offer because of what you witnessed. +

While this is understandable, it may be premature or even naive. Perhaps there are perfectly good explanations for everything you witnessed—the person who was turned away had already received food that day, the family receiving extra was picking up for a neighbor, and the person who seemed unattended had asked several times to be left alone. Ultimately, it's important to carefully consider all factors before making a decision. If you still decline, communicate openly and respectfully with the organization about your decision.

3. Discovering Malfeasance



You've been working at the food bank for six months. It's long hours and modest compensation, but you feel good about the work you do. You respect your manager, admire their work ethic, and believe in their integrity. You believe that everyone you work with is "Ru"—that is, humane in thoughts and actions. They all are really good people.

But one day you walk into the office unannounced and see your manager with their hand in the cash box. They quickly explain that they are just "borrowing" money for lunch because they left their wallet at home, and intend to pay it back. They also say they aren't hurting anyone by doing this, which you recognize as a utilitarian approach. Despite that, you feel this is unethical, and moreover, that they might be lying about paying the money back. They offer to buy you lunch too, which feels like a bribe.

You decline the lunch but feel conflicted and unsure of what to do next. On one hand, you don't want to cause any trouble or create drama in the workplace. Furthermore, negative news could harm the reputation of the food bank, affect donations, and thus hurt the people you want to help. On the other hand, you feel that what your manager was doing is wrong and unethical.



What do you do when you discover the manager is taking money from the local food bank?

You report the incident publicly at a meeting of the board of directors.

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This is a difficult decision, but you feel it is the right thing to do. You have a responsibility to the company and to your fellow coworkers to maintain a safe and ethical work environment. While this is highly public, you feel it takes away any chance to bury or cover up the incident. It takes courage to stand up for what is right, even when it's difficult. Hopefully, your actions will result in a positive change for the company and its employees.

Tell the manager to replace the money and quit, or you will tell the board of directors.

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This is essentially blackmail, or demanding payment or another benefit from someone in return for not revealing information about them. Even though you tell yourself it's just to give the manager a chance to save face, you also know you may be promoted once the manager leaves. Is attaining the manager's position through blackmail, even though you might have good intentions, really ethical?

Tell the executive director of the organization privately.

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This is more tactful than reporting the issue publicly, but also less certain. The organization can save face, but it's also possible the director will simply dismiss the concern. If the director disciplines the manager but does not fire them, you will now report to a manager who may retaliate against you, such as giving poor performance reviews, or at the very least, being cool and distant instead of mentoring and supporting you.

You decide to do nothing.

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You tell the manager they'd better put the money back, and they say they will, but you do not really know. If the manager has stolen once, odds are they have done it before, and will do it again. While you feel it is not your concern, doing nothing is still making a choice, and makes you an accessory to unethical behavior.



SUMMARY

In this lesson, you made decisions where there is pressure to behave unethically, starting with an **uneasy interview** where you are encouraged to show ethical flexibility. As you **continue your job search**, you witness what may be unethical behavior, but accept the job. You subsequently **discover malfeasance** at the job and need to handle it ethically and gracefully.

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